

CKG Song Archiving Project

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By: Medur

The creation of an archive of Sri Chinmoy's songs is approaching a crossroad. The current library consists of 23,028 songs, of which there remain about 2,000 songs yet to be transcribed into ABC notation. When this task is completed sometime in late 2024 further progress can be made in various directions. It is the purpose of this proposal to discuss this further progress, in the hopes of deciding what can, in fact, be done. This could conceivably be followed up with a road map for future action, with a tentative timeline.

Following is a list of issues that have arisen during the ABC transcription process, and in discussions with others. This list is a work in progress, any issues not addressed here can be added, as this is, indeed one of the aims of this proposal.

Consider the following (not in any prioritized order):

- Presentation in August: Should anything about this project be worthy of presentation in some form in August in New York?
- Authority: During the abc transcription process questions of style preference came up which need to be discussed. A style guide would serve well. Many decisions need to be made that require responsible and musically literate experience. To this end it is proposed that a music committee be formed to make decisions and authorize an appropriate set of rules. The composition of this committee is an important issue requiring attention and discussion.
- Songbooks: There are over 300 published songbooks containing songs from the library along with unpublished collections of songs. These songbooks and collections are not properly recorded in the existing database, so this will be a small but significant contribution to the integrity of the archive. One approach would be to allow for the creation of arbitrary lists of songs, (think of an iTunes playlist), with optional title, ISBN number, publish date, etc. . . .
- Standardization: over the years it has taken to create the database of ABC transcriptions, many contributors have helped, with some divergence in ABC styles and decorations. This variation can be addressed. Is a standardization policy necessary? A related question is: Should the ABC transcription faithfully reflect exactly original song score? e.g. glissando vs slide issue, consistent application of styles inside and across different songs, replication of errors or oversights in original published scores ...

- Newly discovered songs: New songs are being found on an ongoing basis during the process of archiving other materials (audio tapes, paper filing etc). These new items need to be inserted into the database.
- Error detection and correction: This can be set up as an ongoing task over an extended period, performed by selected individuals who have the appropriate qualifications for this purpose. Deciding who should do this is an important issue.
- Alternate versions of songs: Many songs were revised and updated after initially being composed and became officially sanctioned. In addition a song can be made available in multiple display formats (for publishing, audio production etc.). A means to provide for these versions is not fully implemented as of now.
- Conversion of songs into the Songscribe format is desired for high quality rendition for print publishing purposes. This feature will require some database modification.
- ABC notation deficiencies: The current method for rendering ABC into song scores is not fully compatible with the songs in the library. This will require some analysis followed up by the creation a list of ABC codes for completeness and simplification. The songscribe format requires this list to be fully useful.
- Long Songs: There are several very long songs in the database which do not yet have an appropriate means to be rendered into ABC. This is a technical issue which can be addressed at some point.
- Zlin archive: The archiving project in Zlin is not fully linked with the current song database. The archive has several independent indexes (Kailash group numbers, Moni list, Primary key in the Zlin database etc.) This matter is an ongoing issue and can be worked on over the next year.
- Exposing the song database to a wider audience: Is it time to open the library to others? Is there still too much uncertainty in the air to allow this? Collecting background stories about songs is an ongoing concern, as time passes. . .

The following page shows an example of a song which has been transcribed into ABC notation. This is provided as an illustration of the output of the ABC transcription process. It was selected because it demonstrates several examples of the discussion points made above.

(Note the treatment of the glissandi and grace notes between the two images, and, in general, the differences between the two images.)

Nirabe ami daki tomai gopane

Journey's Goal 10b, page 5

From page in songbook:

5. Nirabe Ami Daki Tomai Gopane

$\text{♩} = 120$ Moderate

The musical score is written on four staves in G major (one sharp) and 4/4 time. The tempo is marked 'Moderate' with a quarter note equal to 120 beats. The lyrics are written below the notes. The first staff ends with a double bar line and the word 'fine'. The second staff continues the melody. The third staff continues the melody. The fourth staff ends with a double bar line and the word 'D.C.'.

Ni-ra-be a-mi da-ki to-mai go-pa-ne

pu--ji----- to-mai ni---dra-----

----- gu-hai swa-pa-ne----- ne-----

D.C.

SVG image from ABC text:

$\text{♩} = 120$ Moderate

The SVG image shows the same musical score as the previous block, but with a different layout. The lyrics are written below the notes. The first staff ends with a double bar line and the word 'fine'. The second staff continues the melody. The third staff continues the melody. The fourth staff ends with a double bar line and the word 'fine'.

Ni - ra - be a - mi da - ki to - mai go - pa-ne

Pu - ji ----- to-mai ni - dra -----

Gu - hai swa-pa-ne ----- ne -----

(e) -----

ABC text

```
%graceword 1
X:1
I:abc-charset utf-8
%%rightmargin 220pt
T:Nirabe ami daki tomai gopane
C:Words and Music
C:By Sri Chinmoy
C:
M:none
L:1/8
Q:1/4=120 " Moderate"
K:Gb
Bcd2B2Bc (AB)B2z2G2{/G}!~(!B4!~)!FG{/G}B8"^fine"y|]
w:Ni-ra-be a-mi_ da--ki to-mai go-pa-ne
=c2c4B=cd3=cd8=cd(e2_c3/2)B//A//x B3/2A//=G// A=G (A2E2)|
w:Pu-ji__ to-mai ni--dra_____
z2E2!breath!A8z2BcB4-BA B2 !~(!c6!~)!e6 d2c3BA2|
w:Gu-hai swa-pa-ne__ ne_____
=G2A2B2 !~(!c4!~)!A2 z2=GA{/FAB}c3BA2=G2A8:|
w:(e)_____
%%leftmargin 490pt
%%text D.C. al fine
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